

## Area of Study 2D – Buddhism

### Overview

This area of study comprises a study in depth of Buddhism as a lived religion within the United Kingdom and throughout the world, and its beliefs and teachings on life, specifically about the issues of peace and conflict, and crime and punishment.

There are four sections: Buddhist Beliefs, Crime and Punishment, Living the Buddhist Life and Peace and Conflict.

The significance and importance of the various beliefs, issues and practices to Buddhists today should be explored throughout the sections. This should include reference to how scripture informs a Buddhist's understanding of the topics and how approaches to the issues are underpinned by philosophical arguments and ethical theory as applicable.

Students will be expected to study Buddhism within the context of the wider British society, the religious traditions of which are, in the main, Christian. Students should compare and contrast the areas of belief and practice within Buddhism with Christianity as outlined in the content below.

- Beliefs about the afterlife and their significance (1.5)\*
- The practice and significance of worship (3.6)\*

Students should recognise that Buddhism is one of the many religions and world views in Great Britain, which include Hinduism, Judaism, Islam, Sikhism and non-religious views such as Humanism and atheism. This knowledge may be applied throughout the assessment of the specified content.

Students should compare and contrast the areas of ethics and/or philosophy within Buddhism and non-religious views as outlined in the content below.

Students should also recognise that within Buddhism there may be more than one perspective in the way beliefs and teachings are understood and expressed. Common and divergent views within Buddhism in the way beliefs and teachings are understood and expressed should be included throughout, including reference to Theravada and Mahayana traditions.

**Students should have an understanding of:**

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| <b>1.1</b>  | The life of the Buddha: the nature and history of the events in the life of the Buddha and why they are important to Buddhists today, including ancestry, birth, princely life, marriage and the Four Sights, with reference to Buddhavamsa XXVI; the enlightenment of the Buddha and founding of the Sangha.                                                                                                                                           |
| <b>1.2</b>  | Dhamma: the nature and different meaning of dhamma (dependent origination /conditionality); the nature and importance of paticca-samuppada and the Three Marks of Existence, including reference to the Story of Nagasena and the Chariot in the Milinda Panha; suffering (dukkha), no fixed self (anicca) and soul or essence (anatta); the implications of belief in dhamma for Buddhists today.                                                      |
| <b>1.3</b>  | First Noble Truth, including reference to the Dhammacakkappavattana Sutta: the nature of dukkha; Buddhist teachings about suffering; the different types of suffering as pain, fabrication and change; the importance of suffering for Buddhists today.                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| <b>1.4</b>  | Second Noble Truth, including reference to Dhammacakkappavattana Sutta: the nature of samudaya (the root of suffering); Buddhist teachings about the causes of suffering, including the Sermon at Benares; the Three Poisons and how they are represented in the Wheel of Life; divergent understandings of the Wheel of Life, with reference to Theravada and Mahayana Buddhism.                                                                       |
| <b>1.5*</b> | Third Noble Truth, including reference to the Dhammacakkappavattana Sutta: the nature of nirodha and the cessation of tanha; Buddhist teachings about the ending of desire; the nature of the cycle of samsara; different understandings of nibbana and enlightenment and their importance for Buddhists today.                                                                                                                                         |
| <b>1.6</b>  | Fourth Noble Truth, including reference to the Dhammacakkappavattana Sutta: the nature of the Middle Way (magga); Buddhist teachings about the Eightfold Path leading to nibbana. The Threefold Way: the nature, purpose and importance of sila (ethics), samadhi (meditation) and panna (wisdom); divergent understandings of the importance Eightfold Path and the Threefold Way for Buddhist life today.                                             |
| <b>1.7</b>  | Human life: divergent Buddhist understandings of the nature and importance of the Five Khandas (aggregates), including the Khandha Sutta; divergent Buddhist understandings of the nature and importance of sunnata and tathagatagarbha (Buddha-nature); divergent Buddhist understandings of the nature and importance of Arahant and Bodhisattva Ideals; divergent Buddhist understandings of the nature and history of Buddhahood and the Pure Land. |
| <b>1.8</b>  | Buddhist ethical teachings: divergent Buddhist understandings of the nature, purpose and importance of kamma, including Dhammapada 181–187 and the Khuddakapatha, merit and rebirth, karuna (compassion), metta (loving kindness), pancha sila (the Five Precepts) and the paramitas (Six Perfections); the divergent applications of each of these ethical teachings in Buddhist life today.                                                           |

**Students should have an understanding of:**

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| <b>2.1</b> | Buddhist attitudes towards justice: Buddhist teachings about the nature of justice and why justice is important for Buddhists, including Dhammapada 256–257; Buddhist teachings on why justice is important for the victim; non-religious attitudes (including atheist and Humanist) about why justice is important regardless of religion and belief, and Buddhist responses to them.                                                                                         |
| <b>2.2</b> | Buddhist attitudes towards crime: Buddhist teachings about and responses to the nature, causes and problem of crime, including Dhammapada 160–165; what action is taken by Buddhist individuals and Buddhist groups to end crime, including the Prison Dharma Network/Prison Mindfulness.                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| <b>2.3</b> | Buddhist teachings about good, evil and suffering: Buddhist teachings about the nature of good actions, how they are rewarded, and teachings about the nature of evil actions; non-religious attitudes (including atheist and Humanist) about why people suffer, including believing in religion and Buddhist responses to them; divergent Buddhist teachings about why people suffer, including the words of the XIV Dalai Lama’s Nobel acceptance speech (10 December 1989). |
| <b>2.4</b> | Buddhist attitudes towards punishment: divergent Buddhist teachings and attitudes towards the nature and use of punishment, including Dhammapada 197–202 and links to situation ethics; Buddhist teachings on why punishment can be regarded as justice and why punishment might be needed in society.                                                                                                                                                                         |
| <b>2.5</b> | Buddhist attitudes towards the aims of punishment: divergent Buddhist attitudes towards each of the aims of punishment (protection, retribution, deterrence and reformation); Buddhist teachings about punishment, including Bhaddali Sutta.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| <b>2.6</b> | Buddhist teachings about forgiveness: Buddhist teachings and responses about the nature and importance of forgiveness, including Dhammapada 3–10, how offenders are forgiven by the community and why this is needed; Buddhist responses to the nature and use of restorative justice, and why it is important for criminals.                                                                                                                                                  |
| <b>2.7</b> | Buddhist teachings about the treatment of criminals: Buddhist teachings about the treatment of criminals, including Dhammapada 129–140; divergent Buddhist attitudes towards the use of torture, human rights, fair trial and trial by jury; the application of ethical theories such as situation ethics and Buddhist responses to them.                                                                                                                                      |
| <b>2.8</b> | Buddhist attitudes towards the death penalty: the nature and purpose of capital punishment; divergent Buddhist teachings about the nature, purpose and arguments surrounding the use of capital punishment, including Brahmajala Sutta 1; non-religious (including atheist and Humanist) attitudes towards the use of capital punishment, including the application of ethical theories, such as situation ethics, and Buddhist responses to them.                             |

**Students should have an understanding of:**

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| <b>3.1</b>  | Meditation: the nature, purpose and significance of meditation in Buddhism; the different types of meditation: samatha (concentration), metta bhavana (loving kindness) and vipassana (insight); meditative practices, including mindfulness breathing and zazen, divergent understanding of the nature and importance of visualisation of the Buddha and Bodhisattvas, including Amitāyus Meditation Sutra; how the different practices are used by Mahayana and Theravada Buddhists and the benefits from their use. |
| <b>3.2</b>  | Chanting: the nature, purpose and role of chanting in Buddhism as a devotional practice and to gain mental concentration, including Dhammapada 1–2, confidence and joy. The divergent understandings of the importance of chanting in Buddhist life today: Theravada Buddhism, including Tiratana Buddhism, with reference to Dhammapada 190, and Mahayana Buddhism, including Nam Myoho Renge Kyo.                                                                                                                    |
| <b>3.3</b>  | Mantra recitation: divergent understandings of the nature, purpose, role and importance of mantra recitation with reference to Theravada Buddhism, including Namo Buddhaya ('Homage to the Buddha'), and Mahayana Buddhism; the nature and purpose of using sacred syllables, devotional articles, offerings and mala beads and why they are used in different schools of Buddhism.                                                                                                                                    |
| <b>3.4</b>  | Features of Buddhist places of worship: the divergent nature, history and design of Buddhist places of worship, including temples, gompas, viharas, shrines in Theravada, Mahayana and Triratna Buddhism; how and why the places of worship are used, including reference to the shrine room, shrine facing east, and the library, showing the importance of learning with reference to the Kimsila Sutta.                                                                                                             |
| <b>3.5</b>  | How and why objects of devotion are used within different Buddhist places of worship, buddharupas, including reference to Vakkali Sutta, shrine, Bodhi tree; divergent understandings of why devotional objects are important in Buddhism today.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| <b>3.6*</b> | Puja: the nature and purpose of puja in the vihara and the home, including reference to Mangala Sutta; examples of the different types; when each type might be used and why; the importance of having different types of worship and their use in different Buddhist contexts.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| <b>3.7</b>  | Death and mourning rituals and ceremonies: the divergent celebration and significance of the ceremonies in Buddhist communities and to Buddhists; the distinct significance of the rituals associated with death and mourning in Theravada communities and in Japan and Tibet, with reference to the <i>Tibetan Book of the Dead</i> .                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| <b>3.8</b>  | Festivals and retreats: the divergent nature, history, purpose and importance of festivals and retreats in Buddhism; divergent understandings of the origins, meaning and features of celebration of specific festivals and retreats, including Wesak, Vassa/Rain Retreat and Kathina, with reference to the Anapanasati Sutta, and Uposatha days in Theravada Buddhism; Hanamatsuri and Obon (Japanese), Parinibbana Day in Mahayana Buddhism, and Lama Tsong Khapa Day in Tibet.                                     |

**Students should have an understanding of:**

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| <b>4.1</b> | Buddhist attitudes towards peace: Buddhist teachings about the nature and importance of peace, including Dhammapada 197–208; Buddhism as a religion of peace and how this may be understood differently in the life of a Buddhist.                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| <b>4.2</b> | The role of Buddhists in peacemaking: Buddhist teachings about peacemaking; the importance for Buddhists of justice, forgiveness and reconciliation in peacemaking, including Dhammapada 1–8; the work of Buddhists working for peace today, the divergent approaches in what they do and why they try to work for peace, including the Buddhist Peace Fellowship.                                                                      |
| <b>4.3</b> | Buddhist attitudes to conflict: Buddhist teachings and responses to the nature and causes of conflict, including links to the Three Poisons and Itivuttaka 50; Buddhist responses to the problems conflict causes within society and links to situation ethics; non-religious (including atheist and Humanist) attitudes about the role of religion in the causes of conflict and Buddhist responses to them.                           |
| <b>4.4</b> | Buddhist attitudes to pacifism: Buddhist teachings and responses to the nature and history of pacifism, including links to the Five Precepts and Cunda Kammaraputta Sutta; Buddhist teachings about passive resistance and examples of its use within Buddhism.                                                                                                                                                                         |
| <b>4.5</b> | Buddhist attitudes to the Just War theory: Buddhist teachings and responses to the nature and importance of the Just War theory; divergent opinions on whether the Just War theory should be rejected by Buddhists, including reference to War and Peace: A Buddhist Perspective by the Venerable Bhikkhu Bodhi; the application of ethical theories such as situation ethics.                                                          |
| <b>4.6</b> | Buddhist attitudes to war: Buddhist teachings about war and peace, including teachings about skilfulness in the Sammaditthi Sutta, and fighting with reference to the Kakacupama Sutta; divergent applications of Buddhist principles and involvement on war.                                                                                                                                                                           |
| <b>4.7</b> | Buddhist attitudes to weapons of mass destruction (WMD): Buddhist teaching and responses to the problems and benefits of WMD; Buddhist attitudes towards the use of such weapons, including Dhammapada 129–145; non-religious attitudes (including atheist and Humanist) and the application of ethical theories (such as utilitarianism) which support the acquisition of weapons of mass destruction, and Buddhist responses to them. |
| <b>4.8</b> | Buddhist responses to issues surrounding conflict: Buddhist teachings and responses to the nature of problems involved in conflict – violence, war and terrorism, including Karaniya Metta Sutta; how Buddhists have worked to overcome these issues, including Engaged Buddhism.                                                                                                                                                       |